HOW IT UNFOLDED
DATED & SOURCED

TECHNOLOGY HISTORY

Three patents for early record players

Edison's phonograph and Berliner's gramophone left separate records of how sound was captured and played back.

19 FEB 1878

Edison's phonograph

Thomas Edison received U.S. patent 200,521 for a phonograph that recorded sound as indentations in a moving surface.

U.S. patent 200,521

8 NOV 1887

Berliner's gramophone

Emile Berliner received U.S. patent 372,786 for a gramophone. The record describes tracking a groove to reproduce sound.

U.S. patent 372,786

15 MAY 1888

Making a sound record

A later Berliner patent described making a sound record by etching a trace into a prepared metal surface.

U.S. patent 382,790

Reading the record

The dates identify patent grants. Look to sales records for when the products reached buyers.

Full timeline and sources